A Little Princess

A simplified retelling

Original story by Frances Hodgson Burnett

The same journey. Clearer, shorter English.

Abridged and retold for Speak Boldly Intermediate reading practice

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1. Sara’s new school

Captain Crewe brought his daughter Sara from India to a girls’ school in London. He loved her dearly and wanted her to have every comfort while he was away.

Miss Minchin, the headmistress, was delighted to receive a wealthy pupil. Sara had a private room, fine clothes and a maid. She also had a doll, Emily, whom she treated as a companion.

But Sara was not especially interested in showing that she had more than the other girls. She loved books and invented stories. She helped Ermengarde, who struggled with lessons, and comforted little Lottie, who missed her mother.

She also noticed Becky, a young servant who worked hard and was often exhausted. Instead of treating her as invisible, Sara spoke to her kindly and shared stories with her.

Some girls admired Sara. Lavinia resented her importance. Sara tried to imagine being a princess, not because a princess owned fine things, but because she hoped such a person would behave with courage and

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generosity.

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2. The birthday message

On Sara’s eleventh birthday, the school prepared a special celebration. Then a visitor arrived with terrible news.

Her father had died. He was believed to have lost his money in a diamond-mine investment. Sara had no fortune and no parent to come for her.

Miss Minchin’s kindness disappeared immediately. She felt cheated because she had expected Captain Crewe to pay for Sara’s expensive care. She took away Sara’s possessions and moved her into an attic room.

Sara would remain at the school, but not as an ordinary pupil. She would run errands, help with lessons and work wherever she was needed. Becky slept nearby.

Everything familiar had changed in a few hours. Sara could not imagine a story that made her father’s death less painful. Still, she tried to hold on to the idea that losing money did not require her to lose her character.

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3. Life in the attic

The attic was cold and uncomfortable. Sara was often hungry, and Miss Minchin found reasons to criticise her. Some pupils copied the headmistress’s unkindness.

Others remained loyal. Ermengarde brought friendship, Lottie came to see her, and Becky shared what little she could. Sara told them stories in which the attic became a different place. Imagination could not provide a real fire, but it helped them endure the hours.

A rat sometimes appeared in her room. Sara gave him a name, Melchisedec, and left him crumbs. She watched people in the neighbouring houses and imagined their lives.

One day, a boy from a large family nearby mistook her for a beggar and gave her a coin. Sara accepted it with dignity. Later, the family remembered the unusual little girl.

Being generous had been easy when she owned plenty. Now Sara had to discover whether she could remain generous when she needed help herself.

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4. The buns

On a wet day, Sara found a small coin in the street. She was extremely hungry and went into a bakery to buy buns. The woman behind the counter gave her extra.

Outside, Sara saw a girl who looked even hungrier than she felt. The girl, Anne, had almost nothing. Sara gave her most of the buns and walked away with only a little food for herself.

The baker had watched. She brought Anne inside and began helping her regularly.

Sara did not know what followed her small action. She knew only that she had seen someone in greater need and could not ignore her.

Back at school, the cold and hard work continued. Sara sometimes struggled to behave as she wished. She was a frightened, grieving child, not a magical creature without anger. Her effort mattered because kindness was difficult, not because it came without difficulty.

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5. The man next door

A sick man named Mr Carrisford moved into the neighbouring house with his Indian servant, Ram Dass. Carrisford had been Captain Crewe’s business partner.

The diamond investment had not failed after all. It had become valuable, but Captain Crewe had died before learning this. Carrisford was trying to find his friend’s daughter so that he could restore her fortune and care for her.

He believed she might be at a school in another country. He did not know she was living in the attic next door.

Ram Dass saw Sara and became concerned about her room. With Carrisford’s agreement, he quietly arranged a surprise. Sara returned one evening to find warmth, food and beautiful things where there had been almost nothing.

She and Becky could scarcely believe it. For once, the wonderful transformation belonged to the room itself, not only to a story.

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6. A name recognised

Sara left a note thanking the unknown friend who had helped her. Meanwhile, Carrisford continued searching in the wrong places.

Then Ram Dass’s monkey escaped into Sara’s attic. She brought it back to the house next door. During their conversation, Carrisford learned her name and heard about her father.

At last, the search was over.

Sara learned that she was not penniless and that her father’s friend had been looking for her. Carrisford offered her a home. Miss Minchin tried to recover control of the situation, but her treatment of Sara was now known. She could not simply make herself kind by changing her tone.

Sara left the school. Becky was able to join her as a companion and helper in a far gentler life.

Later, Sara returned to the bakery and arranged for hungry children to receive food. She discovered that Anne was now working there. A few shared buns had

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helped begin a lasting change.

Sara’s fortune had returned. The most important things she had tried to preserve had never depended on it.

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Words to keep

Fortune — a large amount of money or valuable property. Sara was thought to have lost her fortune.

Dignity — self-respect shown in the way you behave. Sara tried to respond with dignity.

Errand — a short journey to complete a task. She ran errands for the school.

Investment — money put into a project in the hope that it will grow. The mine investment became valuable.

Loyal — continuing to support someone in difficulty. Ermengarde remained loyal to Sara.

Generosity — willingness to share or give help. Sharing the buns was an act of generosity.

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A question to carry with you

Which of Sara’s actions would still matter if her fortune had never returned? What does that suggest about the story’s idea of a princess?

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